

Building an Employee Handbook

12 steps • 20 min read • Available from the Launchpad plan

A handbook is where day-to-day workplace expectations get written down once, instead of negotiated informally every time something goes wrong. Done well, it is also your first line of defence in a CCMA dispute, because it shows employees were told the rules in advance.

WHY IT MATTERS

- Disciplinary action is far harder to defend without a documented, communicated policy the employee was aware of.
- A handbook signals professionalism to new hires and to investors reviewing your HR maturity during diligence.
- Policies (leave, remote work, harassment, social media) change faster than contracts — a handbook lets you update expectations without renegotiating every contract.

Step-by-step

1

Set the scope of the handbook

Decide which policies you need now versus later: leave, working hours, code of conduct, disciplinary code, grievance procedure, harassment, and remote/hybrid work are the core starting set.

2

Draft the leave policy

Reflect BCEA minimums for annual, sick, family responsibility, and parental leave, plus any enhancements you choose to offer.

3

Draft the working hours and overtime policy

State ordinary hours, overtime approval process, and rest period rules in plain language.

4

Draft the code of conduct

Set expectations on attendance, dress, use of company property, and conflicts of interest.

5

Draft the disciplinary code and procedure

Include an incremental sanctions approach and a fair process (notice, hearing, right of representation, appeal) aligned with the LRA Code of Good Practice.

6

Draft the grievance procedure

Give employees a clear, low-friction path to raise concerns before they escalate to the CCMA.

7

Draft the anti-harassment and equality policy

Cover harassment, discrimination, and reporting channels, consistent with the Employment Equity Act.

8

Draft remote/hybrid work rules (if relevant)

Set expectations on availability, equipment, expenses, and data security for anyone working outside the office.

9

Draft the social media and confidentiality policy

Protect trade secrets and client information, and set boundaries for public commentary about the business.

10

Run the Employee Handbook Generator wizard

Assemble every section above into one receiver-grade document with plain-language previews for employee sign-off.

11

Circulate for acknowledgement and e-signature

Route the handbook to every employee for a recorded acknowledgement — this acknowledgement is what makes the handbook enforceable later.

12

Version and file in the Company Snapshot

Store the current version, the acknowledgement list, and a changelog so future updates are traceable and previous versions remain available as evidence.

Quick checklist

- Leave, hours, and overtime policies drafted to BCEA minimums
- Disciplinary code and grievance procedure aligned to the LRA
- Anti-harassment and equality policy included
- Remote work and confidentiality rules addressed
- Handbook generated as one receiver-grade document
- Employee acknowledgements collected and e-signed
- Current version filed in the Company Snapshot

RELATED WIZARDS — JUMP STRAIGHT IN

→ **Employee Handbook Generator**

This playbook is general guidance for South African startups and SMEs and is not a substitute for advice on your specific circumstances. Run the linked wizards on The StartUp Legal platform to generate, negotiate, and e-sign the actual documents — each completed run produces a receiver-grade document, a full evidence pack, and an update to your Company Snapshot.